

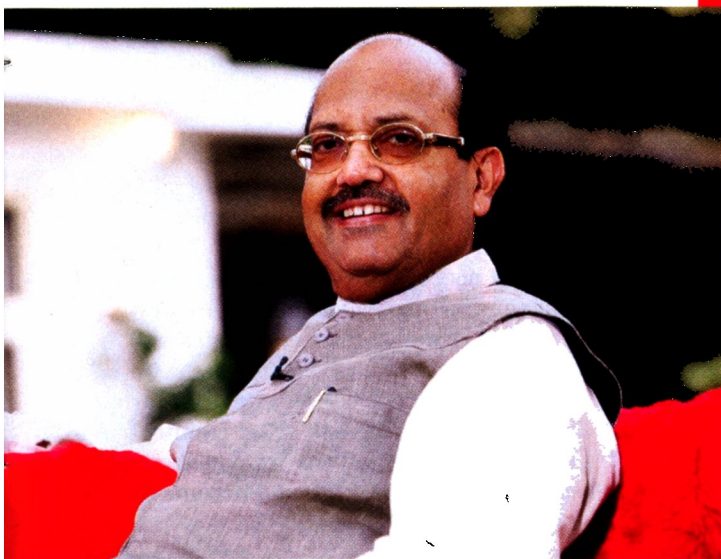
Over The MOON

G. Madhavan Nair

He promised India the moon, and gave it. When G. Madhavan Nair took over as chairman of Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) five years ago, among his tasks was to create a whole new vision for one of the country's most successful public sector institutions. ISRO had already demonstrated that it could indigenously design state-of-the-art satellites and build sophisticated rocketry to launch them into desired orbits. Nair decided to take ISRO to where no Indian institution or individual had gone before—first the moon, then possibly Mars and even beyond. As India watched with bated breath, on November 14, 2008, at 8.31 p.m., the lunar impact probe from the orbiting Chandrayaan 1 struck the moon's surface, putting India among a handful of nations in the world to achieve the feat. The successful mission was only one in a long list of ISRO's achievements that sent the country's spirit soaring even as terror strikes and an economic downturn threatened to ground India's ambitions. Under Nair's meticulous stewardship, India joined the big boys in space in 2008.

by Raj Chengappa

His clout is such that if he goes for an appointment with the prime minister, the media begins to speculate about a reshuffle.



BANDEEP SINGH

REUTERS



Nobody's PAWN

V. ANAND

For eight years, the powerful Russian chess bloc kept moving the goalposts but each time they found Viswanathan Anand standing in front of them. India's grandest master was made to win the world chess championship title three times on three continents to be given his just due—but this year he could be denied no more. After a world championship win via knockout in Tehran in 2000, he defeated the world's top seven players in a double round robin in Mexico City in 2007 for the first 'unified' world chess title. But again, the skeptics sniffed saying neither format was 'classical' enough. So finally, when confronted by the Eastern block's poster boy, Vladimir Kramnik in a 'pure' match-play contest over 11 games in Bonn this year, Anand hunched over the table, contemplated his options and played the most decisive move of his career. Kramnik was knocked over like a petulant pawn and the Indian was the undisputed world chess champion. Game over, argument over.

by Sharda Ugra